

What Is Project Scope? Six Steps to Define Yours

Project scope outlines the stakeholders, team members, purpose, budget, deliverables, tasks, and workflows for all projects. If you're a freelancer or project manager who wants to elevate your skills and professional reputation, this article explains why and how to use this planning tool to drive successful outcomes.

Why Defining a Project Scope Matters

Some freelancers and project managers confuse a project scope with a project charter. They are not the same. A project charter announces the project's existence without guidelines. But existence needs a purpose. Guidelines clarify the project scope into a coherent purpose.

A project scope determines who, what, where, when, why, and how to accomplish a project. It sets expectations while providing the workflow and resources to meet them. Stakeholders value this structured planning because it keeps them informed without wasting their most valuable resources: time and money.

Six Benefits of Defining a Project Scope

Team members who work on clearly defined tasks and timelines achieve the overall goal on time and within budget far more consistently. A project scope delivers these six benefits:

- Establishes a clear objective that unifies the team behind a common goal.
- Generates excitement among the team and the client by relaying a shared vision.
- Details tasks, timelines, and budgets for each process so every member understands their parameters.
- Streamlines work so no one complicates the workflow.
- Prepares the team for change requests.
- Prevents scope creep.

These benefits manage expectations without sacrificing momentum, keeping all stakeholders focused and motivated.

Seven Steps to Define the Scope of a Project

Team members need to know the overall goal and the work required to achieve it. These steps activate the project without overwhelming the team, creating an atmosphere of accomplishment rather than struggle.

- Clarify the purpose of the project. Without a clear purpose, there are no objectives. Without objectives, there is no project.
- Quantify your resources. Identify team members, tech, and funds. Without these, you have a wish, not a goal.
- Research obstacles and how to address them. Monitor developments in your company, with clients, in the industry, and in the news.
- Let key stakeholders review your research. They will catch issues you overlooked and surface additional resource ideas.
- Develop a change protocol. Even after stakeholder review, events can affect the supply chain or team.
- Institute a change process. Create a request form and designate final decision-makers who handle change requests with logic and goodwill.
- Write the project scope statement.

The Project Scope Statement

A project scope statement puts the project scope in writing. It can run any length as long as it establishes project motivation, why the project matters, and how the team will and will not handle processes. It defines leadership, responsibilities, resources, review procedures, and change protocols. Anything not included sits out of scope.

Once you complete the statement, contact key stakeholders again for a final review, then green-light the project. After sign-off, share the statement with the team and make it easy for them to report their work through a centralized project management tool.

Avoiding Scope Creep

Scope creep describes changes that disrupt the flow of resources and their established parameters. Common examples include budget increases, missed deadlines, unforeseen work processes, the need for additional team members, and a chaotic work environment.

Project Scope Example

Introduction: Names the who, what, and why. "This medical marketing project by XYZ will create a company website and blog to establish and enhance brand awareness."

Project Scope: Defines the overall purpose, timeline, stakeholders, tasks, and team members. "This project includes marketing research, content strategy and development, SEO, and design for XYZ's new website and blog by December 3, 2024."

Deliverables: Specifies each deliverable. "The team will deliver a seven-page website with a defined visual identity and three 1,000-word blogs per week."

Metrics: Establishes success criteria. "In the first six weeks, the website attracts 1,000 visitors per day and the blog earns 500 reads per day."

Exclusions and Constraints: Identifies what falls out of scope. "This project does not include social media account creation" and "This team is not required to hire contract writers."

Project Scope vs. Product Scope

Product scope is not another term for project scope. Product scope refers to the deliverables themselves: the intentions, capabilities, characteristics, designs, and usability each team member produces. Project scope covers the work your team does; product scope covers the traits of what that work creates.

Conclusion

Understanding how to define project scope separates successful projects from messy attempts. If you need support building that structure, the right tools and the right partner make all the difference. Contact us today to get started.